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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, MAY 31, 2026 • \$6

Dislike of AI centers painted as China plot

But scant evidence that U.S. protests are driven by overseas propaganda

BY EVAN HALPER

Utahns took to the streets of Salt Lake City last week to oppose the construction of a 40,000-acre data center backed by billionaire “Shark Tank” star Kevin O’Leary in the largely undeveloped north-west corner of the state.

His fiery response was quickly echoed by the Trump administration but triggered worries in tech and conservative policy circles that Silicon Valley’s struggles to sell skeptical Americans on the benefits of the artificial intelligence boom could soon become even more difficult.

O’Leary claimed in a video posted Monday that “nefarious accounts out of the country” linked to the Chinese Communist Party were driving the backlash to his project, by flooding Utah with false claims in a foreign-backed influence campaign aimed at stopping America’s AI buildup.

Interior Secretary Doug Burgum echoed those claims on Fox Business on Tuesday. “Any place that’s trying to build data centers is getting bombarded with foreign-directed propaganda to try to block these from being built,” he said. “This is just another attack on the U.S. and our ability to be competitive.” Energy and tech-related think tanks have recently made similar claims.

Neither Burgum nor O’Leary, who is Canadian, shared conclusive evidence backing their claims of malign foreign influence.

The allegations drew criticism from allies of the AI industry and Trump administration, including tech insiders, China hawks, White House-aligned conservatives and Trump voters protesting data center projects in their communities. The detractors said that the

SEE DATA CENTERS ON A8

In Virginia: See where data center generators are polluting the air. B6



PHOTOS BY LORENZO TUGNOLI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Mourners display images of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran’s late supreme leader, in March in Baghdad at a funeral for militia fighters. Jalal Rashidi, below, seen in March, left Iran in the 1980s and describes himself as part of a broader Kurdish opposition movement.

Iranians abroad are sharply split over war. Some would fight; others want regime gone.

BY MUSTAFA SALIM AND LORENZO TUGNOLI

KHABAT, Iraq — On a dirt road strewn with shattered concrete, Jalal Rashidi bent to pick up a shard of jagged debris. A piece of a drone, he said, that crashed into a compound of exiled Iranian Kurds soon after the United States and Israel launched their war on Iran.

About 40 families were preparing to break the Ramadan fast here in northern Iraq on March 5 when drones struck, Rashidi said. They blew out windows, peppered walls with shrapnel and tore open a courtyard.

Rashidi’s pregnant wife, he said, lost their baby. He blamed Iranian-backed militias in Iraq.

Rashidi, 51, who left Iran as a child in the 1980s, was now hopeful, he said, that the war would bring the collapse of the Islamic republic in Tehran — and he was prepared to return to his homeland to help.

SEE IRAN ON A12



Conservative judges’ flashy rulings seen as auditions for high court

BY JULIAN MARK

One judge appears to have dropped his long-standing support for birthright citizenship. Another wrote that the federal judiciary should not demand President Donald Trump’s “homework.” A third opened a recent dissent with a crude term for male genitalia.

As speculation swirls about a potential Supreme Court vacancy, a growing number of fire-brand conservative judges are making themselves hard to ignore. Even without firm signs of an imminent opening at the high court, many lawyers consider the rise in flashy opinions to be a form of auditioning for Trump, known for his appreciation of loyalty and grandiose style.

“Trump, and the people around Trump, are going to try to look for people that they have more confidence in even than the previous set of nominees, and that is going to require some kind of further signals of loyalty to the agenda,” said Daniel Epps, a law professor at Washington

University who closely follows the Supreme Court. “That just increases the incentives to audition as much as possible.”

Justice Samuel A. Alito Jr., 76, is widely seen as the justice most likely to step down after this Supreme Court term ends in about a month. Observers point to Alito’s age and the release of his first book as possible reasons the justice might soon retire. The stalwart conservative also might want to step down before the midterm elections in November, they say, so a Trump-appointed successor could be confirmed before Democrats potentially gain seats in the Senate.

Several recent reports have suggested that Alito has no plans to retire. But Republican leaders in the Senate say they are ready to push through a nomination if Alito does make an exit, with some floating Republican Sens. Ted Cruz (Texas) and Mike Lee (Utah) as potential candidates.

Against this backdrop, a number of fiercely conservative appeals court judges have begun

SEE JUDGES ON A2

A requisite stop on the extraterrestrial circuit

For 26 years, a Colorado attraction has drawn tourists and a stream of alien enthusiasts

BY KARIN BRULLIARD



CHET STRANGE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Savannah Woldengen, a visitor last week to the UFO Watchtower, which rises out of the southern Colorado desert scrub, said she left an offering to let otherworldly beings “know I’m here.”

HOOPER, COLO. — The UFO files now being unveiled by the Pentagon, with their videos of darting orbs and photos of floating shapes, do not surprise Larry Messoline one bit. He’s witnessed such oddities himself.

Messoline pulled out his phone on a recent afternoon and pressed play on a video he took two years ago of a blinking light hovering erratically against the inky sky of Colorado’s vast San Luis Valley. “At 52 seconds, it just flashes and goes away. Ready?” said Messoline, clad in a pressed shirt printed with neon aliens. “Boom,” he whispered as the light vanished.

Messoline, 61, is the manager of the UFO Watchtower, a scrappy roadside attraction that rises out of the southern Colorado desert scrub. For 26 years, it has drawn curious road-trippers and a stream of believers who figure that if the truth is out there, it might well show up here. A thick binder on the desk of the gift shop overflows with testimonies and puzzling photos reflecting more than 300 sightings.

Many bear similarities to the

SEE UFOS ON A10

THE NATION

The Pentagon is seeking troops to attend White House UFC matches. A3

SPORTS

As the Mystics start to jell, no one in the WNBA is having more fun. B1

ARTS & STYLE

The best shows among the weird and wonderful world of TV for children.

BUSINESS

The CEO of Hims & Hers is plotting new ways to upend health care. B7

TRAVEL

Heaps of gelato? Walk away. How to avoid an awful restaurant in Rome.

THE REGION

They hunted for Civil War artifacts. Their discovery was older and rarer. B12



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